



MAPUCHE

ADAPTING AND SURVIVING

FOR HUNDREDS OF YEARS, MAPUCHE CULTURE (their name means “people of the Earth”) dominated the rugged landscapes of present-day Chile and northern Argentina. When the Spanish arrived, the Mapuche refused to be overpowered by them,

Masters of their universe

Mapuche territory is not only harsh, but it is also remarkably varied, from jagged peaks and valleys in the mountains to coastal lowlands and plains. The Mapuche have remained stable and prosperous because they have adapted to these diverse terrains, learned to hunt and farm them skillfully, and established strong community structures based on extended family units called *lofs*.

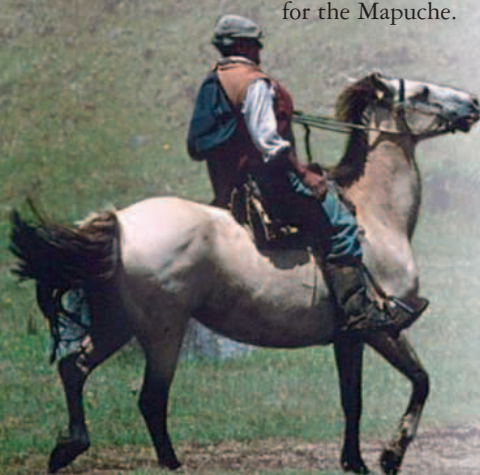
FEMALE SHAMAN

Mapuche priests or shamans, called *machis*, are usually female. This one stands in front of a small hill that has been a sacred site since before the Spanish arrived. On top is a statue of Caupolican, a revered Mapuche chief.



COLONIAL LEGACY

The introduction of horses and cattle by the Spanish had a huge influence on the Mapuche. Most importantly, horses provided greatly increased mobility, which made them much more effective hunters and fighters. Also, both horses and cattle ran wild on the plains, which led to the livestock trading that is still a major source of income for the Mapuche.



HOME LIFE

Inside a family dwelling, called a *ruca*, meals are prepared over an open fire. Domestic chores like cooking and childcare are the sole responsibility of Mapuche women, who also take charge of preserving valued customs and passing them on.

FAMILY HOUSE

Rucas have steeply pitched roofs covered with reed thatch that extends all the way down the walls. Traditionally, *rukas* are built facing east. According to Mapuche belief, the east, from where the sun, moon, and stars rise, is the source of all life forces.

